ably large blocs of the electorate, there's a persistent reluctance to back the RJD—it's still battling an image trap. Against that negative, for that cohort, Nitish's era still evokes happy memories. His firm footing among women and the EBCs (Extremely Backward Classes) is grounded in the material life-chances he opened up for them.

That's also why the NDA rests on an assured base: its combined vote pool in the 2024 LS poll could yield leads in 176 of Bihar's 243 assembly segments. Corruption allegations surface at times against the Nitish government and disappointment runs through parts of the electorate, yet it rarely coalesces into burning outrage. "What is the option?" asks an elderly Muslim man in Nawada, pointing to the lack of a convincing alternative (though he does concede his own family will back Tejashwi's RJD). "That's precisely it," a JD(U) leader explains. "Surveys may show his popularity ebbing, but the moment you pit any individual opponent as a CM alternative, Nitish's ratings spike." The remark captures the contradiction at the heart of his appeal. Ally BJP, too, seems to have realised this. After vacillating on the issue for the longest time, BJP leaders, including Prime Minister Narendra Modi, have been endorsing Nitish as their CM candidate.

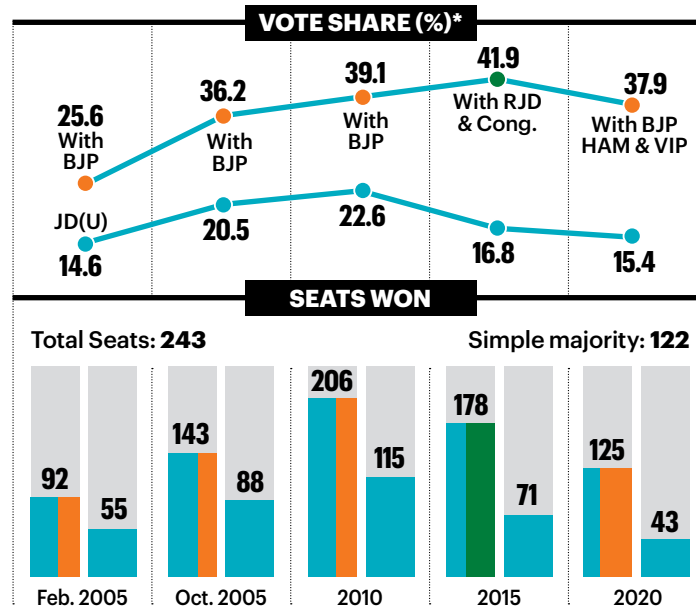
The party, JD(U), is equally resilient. In 2020, when it won just 43 seats, its lowest tally since coming to power, it still polled 32.8 per cent votes across the 115 (out of 243) constituencies it contested. That tally, recorded when parts of ally BJP's base swung towards Chirag Paswan, attests to a durable core, another reason why Nitish remains a prized ally in Bihar's volatile arithmetic.

The NDA has also proved adaptable. When Tejashwi released the MGB manifesto on October 28—promising a government job to one member of every family, Rs 2,500 monthly pension to women, review of the liquor law, et al—the NDA switched gears almost immediately. Their Sankalp Patra, published on October 31, promised 10 million jobs and help for 10 million women to become lakhpatis. Incidentally, even before the poll dates were out, Tejashwi had accused Nitish of filching the Opposition's ideas—the same social security plank (increased pensions, free electricity, domicile in government jobs)—yet the more charitable appraisal is that the latter operationalised those policy cues into subsidy DBTs (Direct Benefit Transfers) and programmes on the ground. Of course, the fact that they blunt the anti-incumbency appeal is a big political advantage for the NDA.

BALLOT BALLAST

Why Nitish's JD(U) is crucial to winning in Bihar

JD(U) | JD(U)+BJP alliance | JD(U)+RJD alliance



*Source: ECI; *Rest, other parties*

The NDA has adapted well, with their Sankalp Patra going above and beyond the Mahagathbandhan's social security poll promises

Alliances and Arithmetic

The BJP has set the campaign tempo, as Modi leads from the front with high-octane roadshows and rallies across key districts. Union home minister Amit Shah has operated as a strategic conductor, sharpening the law and order message and micromanaging organisational deployment, while party president J.P. Nadda criss-crosses the state to stitch up local coalitions into the bigger narrative. The BJP's organisational heft is unmistakable. It has carved the state into five operational zones, deputed '*pravasi pramukhs*' to oversee pockets of influence, and reactivated the panchayat- and booth-level committees with almost corporate discipline. The micro-targeted outreach—volunteers armed with voter lists, grievance trackers, door-to-door activation—is visible in wide swathes of the state.

Crucially, organisation has been matched by alliance engineering. The reintegration of Chirag Paswan and his Lok Janshakti Party (Ram Vilas) into the NDA was painstakingly curated—Nitish visited Chirag's home during Chhath, and the latter publicly touched the CM's feet to get his blessings, gestures intended to erase the bitterness of 2020 and reassure the sceptics. The political math suggests Chirag's presence could swing votes by several percentage points in constituencies where his Dalit/ Paswan base is concen-